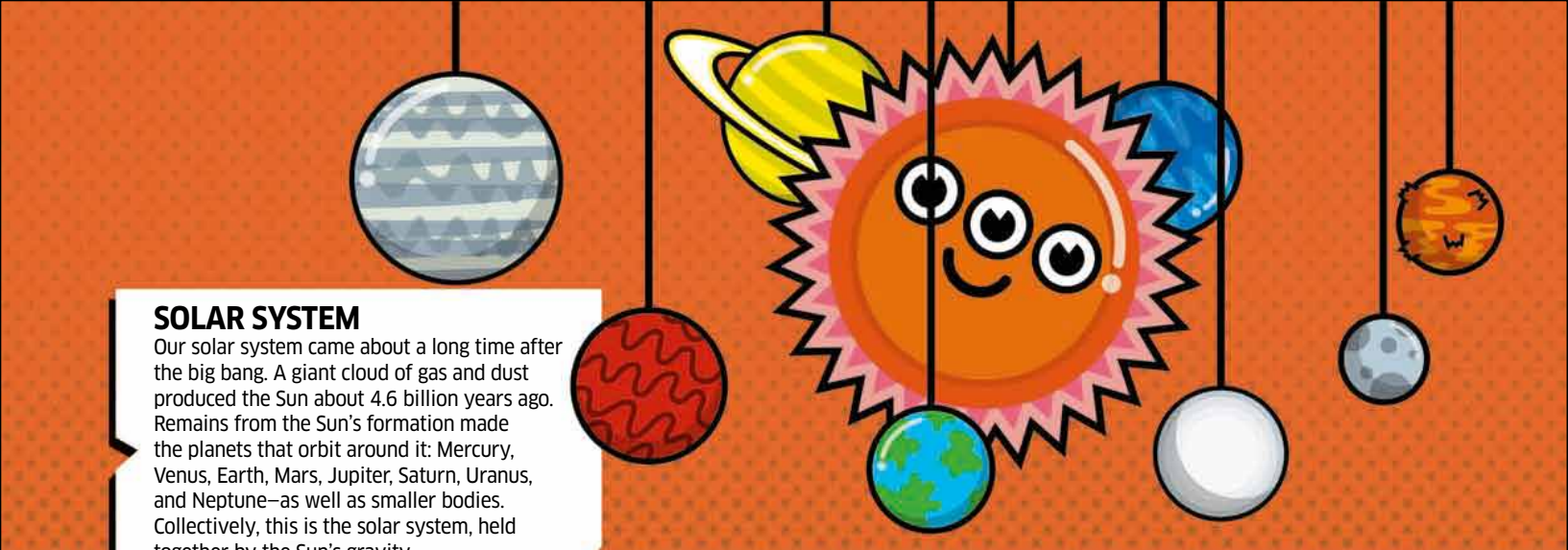




SOLAR SYSTEM

Our solar system came about a long time after the big bang. A giant cloud of gas and dust produced the Sun about 4.6 billion years ago. Remains from the Sun's formation made the planets that orbit around it: Mercury, Venus, Earth, Mars, Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus, and Neptune—as well as smaller bodies. Collectively, this is the solar system, held together by the Sun's gravity.



OUR PLACE

So, where is our place in the universe? About 3.5 billion years ago, carbon-containing molecules in Earth's oceans started to make copies of themselves. They developed into bacteria-like cells—the earliest forms of primitive life. Life continued over time, though it was not until about one million years ago that the first humans walked on Earth. Populations have kept increasing, and today our planet is home to almost seven billion people.



**"THE UNIVERSE IS
WIDER THAN OUR
VIEWS OF IT."**

Henry David Thoreau (1817–1862),
American author



STUDYING THE UNIVERSE

Scientists continue to study the universe from Earth, and new information is being gathered all the time. They use telescopes, computers, satellites, and other equipment to observe stellar and planetary objects and collate data. Robotic craft also explore the solar system at close range and send the findings back to astronomers on Earth. Most astronomers work at universities, while others work for laboratories, government organizations, and observatories.